



As she looked at him, Jaspal would close his fist and bring it close to his chest. "Be brave. All that you need is inside you," he'd say in a wordless sign, hoping that Manu would understand immediately. She didn't need to look at him; she only needed to look within.

The moment of nervousness passed. Manu turned back once more, steely-eyed, towards the targets 10 metres in front of her. She lifted her pistol once again, aimed at the black dot in the centre of the target, and fired. 10.3 – the

score read on the digital board above her. Good enough to bring her back in the medal bracket. She'd never leave it again. While she competed, there was no other moment where even a hint of emotion creased her face.

She'd keep her nerve while others crumbled. Three-time World Cup gold winner Veronica Major was the first to fall. She was followed by Turkey's junior world champion Tarhan Seval Ilayda. China's Asian Games champion Jiang Ranxin dropped out following three shots in

the '8' point ring over four series. World Championship bronze medallist Li Xue exited right after. Finally, it was the turn of Vinh Trinh.

Manu, though, outside of that early blip, was never out of medal contention in the final and was in the silver medal position going into the final shot of the competition. Manu was leading by .1 at that point, but South Korea's Kim Yeji shot 10.5 to the Indian's 10.3 to nose ahead by 0.1.

Relief & joy

It was only then that Manu cracked a wry smile — the first real bits of emotion she'd shown in a while — at what could have been. When she had the medal around her neck, she even wiped away a few tears. It didn't matter at this point. She'd already done more than enough to create history, winning India's first medal at the Paris 2024 Olympics.

It was nerveless shooting in the most stressful of situations. The ability to stay calm can't be taken for granted. And while it may have looked easy, it's something that's been worked on and paid for — in some cases, quite literally.

Priceless training regime

A few weeks ago, after their performance, a street dancing troupe held out a hat in front of two Indians having dinner at a cafe in Luxembourg. They had expected a few coins at most for their efforts. Instead, their eyes bulged as a young woman emptied a stack of Euros into their makeshift bowl.

The slightly glum donor was Manu, who was training in the European country ahead of the Olympic Games. Her generosity was an enforced one, part of a training method employed by the other Indian at the table, Jaspal. It was designed to make sure she'd never let the intensity of training slip. It's a way to replicate, as much as possible, the stress Manu felt at a competition in the otherwise inconsequential environs of a training hall.

As part of the system, Jaspal would set ambitious targets for his shooter. She'll be given a target of,